



unable to find work, or had lost their fortunes, and actually chose to become gladiators. They knew that they would be fed three times a day, have a place to sleep, receive money for every fight, and be given medical care for their injuries. But most of all, they knew that if they could survive long enough, they would be free to return to their families—hopefully with enough money to start their lives over again. This much was good news.

The bad news was that volunteers had to swear an oath. They had to agree to be branded; shackled with chains; whipped with rods; pay for their food with their

VERCINGETORIX, LEADER OF THE GAULS, SURRENDERS TO JULIUS CAESAR IN 52 BCE. THE ROMANS FORCED MANY PRISONERS OF WAR TO BECOME GLADIATORS.

blood; and, if the worst happened, to be killed.

If you think it was only men who fought in the arena, think again. Emperor Domitian put on shows involving women. But a later emperor, Septimius Severus, banned any fights between women in 200 CE.



THIS CARVING SHOWS TWO WOMEN GLADIATORS FIGHTING WITH DAGGERS. THEIR NAMES, AMAZON AND ACHILLIA, MAY HAVE BEEN STAGE NAMES.